UTOPIA IN BETA

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NETWORK SCHOOL

Reimagining land or community?

Forest City

LOCATION

Johor, Malaysia - on the Singapore border

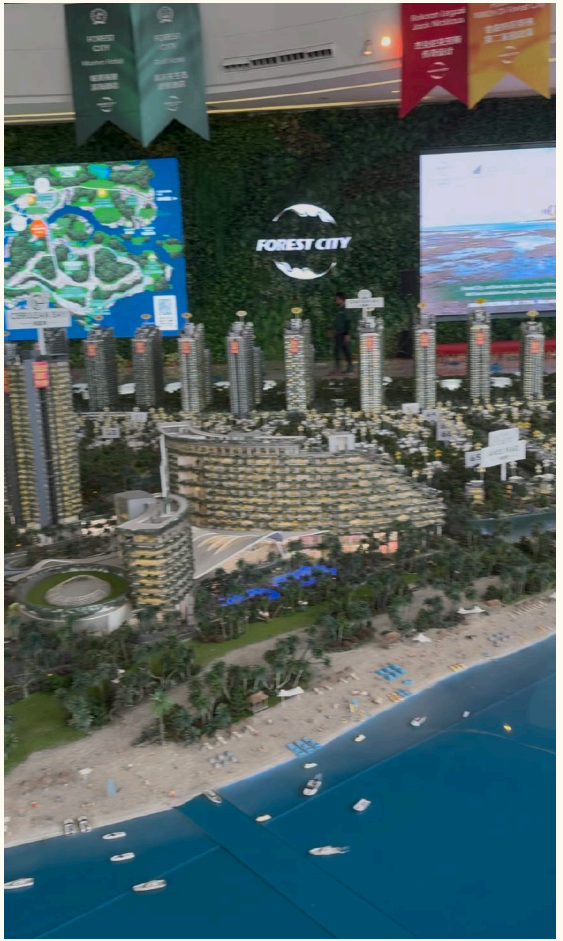
STATUS

15% built

OCCUPANCY

1% full





Network School, Forest City

THE SETUP

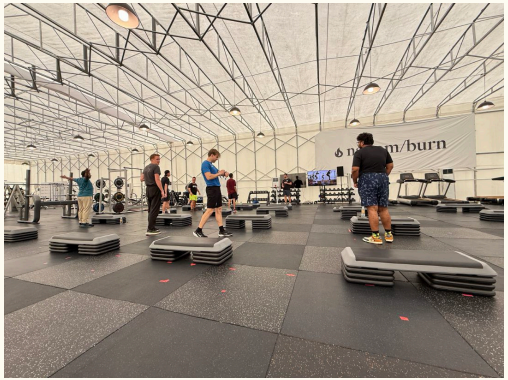
Five-star hotel repurposed as a startup live/work community

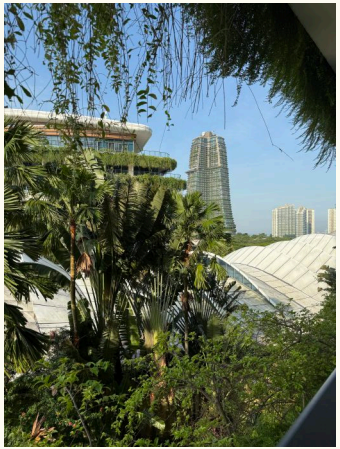
THE PITCH

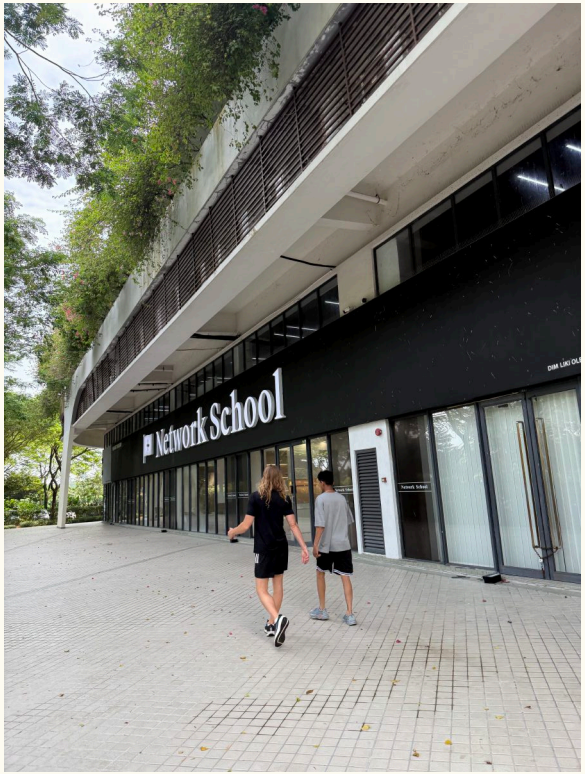
"A new San Francisco" - the ultimate startup city

INFRASTRUCTURE

Workstations, fast wifi (most of the time), meals you just turn up for, gym, pool







Population

Rolling cohorts

Startup founders there for a month or two at a time in a central hotel

Long term population

Smaller population who have signed 12 month leases and are in privately leased apartments



250 residents total

130 long term sign ups

Joining the school

Application to attend

Startup founders there for a month or two at a time in a central hotel

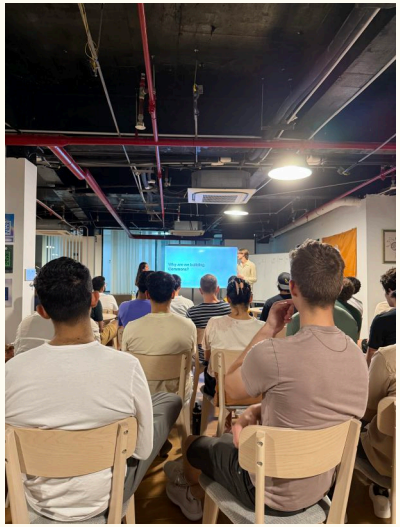
Vs

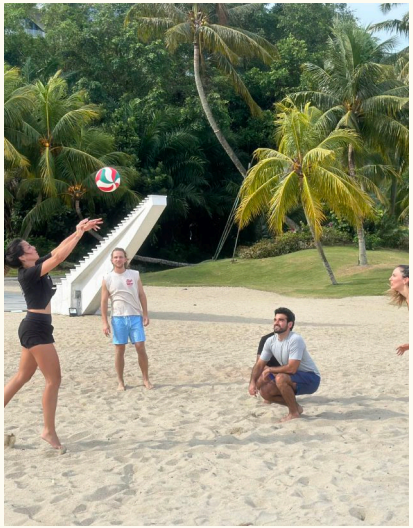
Reach for critical mass

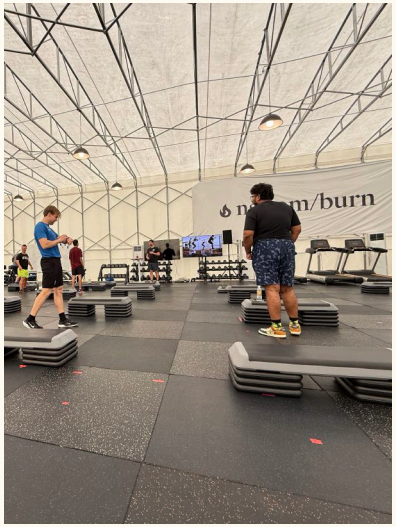
Smaller population who have signed 12 month leases and are in privately leased apartments

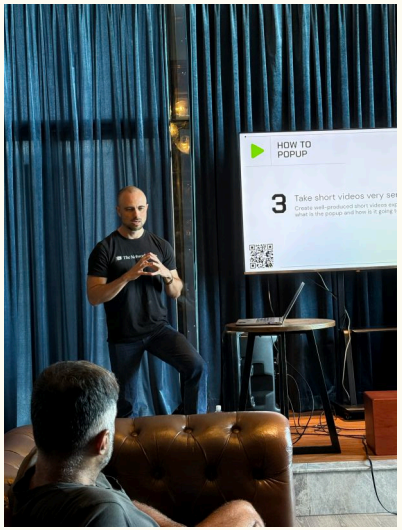


Daily life







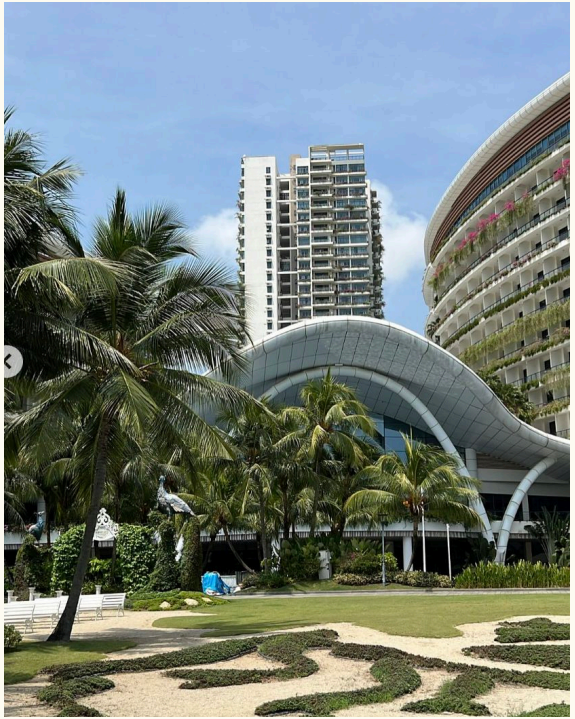


The Community Architecture

01 NETWORK SCHOOL

The infrastructure experiment

~250 residents, marketed as competitive entry, transient digital nomads and startup founders. Open but curated - deciding to go was in itself a filter.







The Community Architecture

02 ÂRC

Layer two - chosen family

Sub-community within NS. Focus on constitutions, religion, governance, long-term societal design. Daily check-ins, exclusive sessions, exclusive "club lounge", mechanism for belonging.







Social structures





What Worked

1. **The filter effect**

   There was some alignment within the community - they are pushing for critical mass though so most applications are now accepted.

2. **Iteration as design philosophy**

   These projects and participants do treat community design as seriously as product design - experiments were retired, improved, iterated weekly.

What Worked

3. **Organic counterbalances**

   Spin-off communities emerged to fill what was missing: slowness, creativity, connection beyond productivity metrics.

4. **Ongoing real connections**

   Groups have since met up in Mexico, Austin and Bangkok. Even if people didn't want to go back it created a point of connection.

The Friction

1. **The pressure cooker dynamic**
   Small community, gossip spreads fast. One wrong move could create a social pariah overnight.
2. **Location as liability**
   Forest City felt like a ghost town. Limited outside contact. Those from cities felt it most acutely.
3. **Narrative control**
   A lot of focus from leadership on making sure public narrative is explicitly positive - can come across as inauthentic and dismissive of community concerns.
4. **The always-on intensity**
   The ambient pressure to perform productivity was constant many people that were there more than a few months needed to leave and come back to decompress.

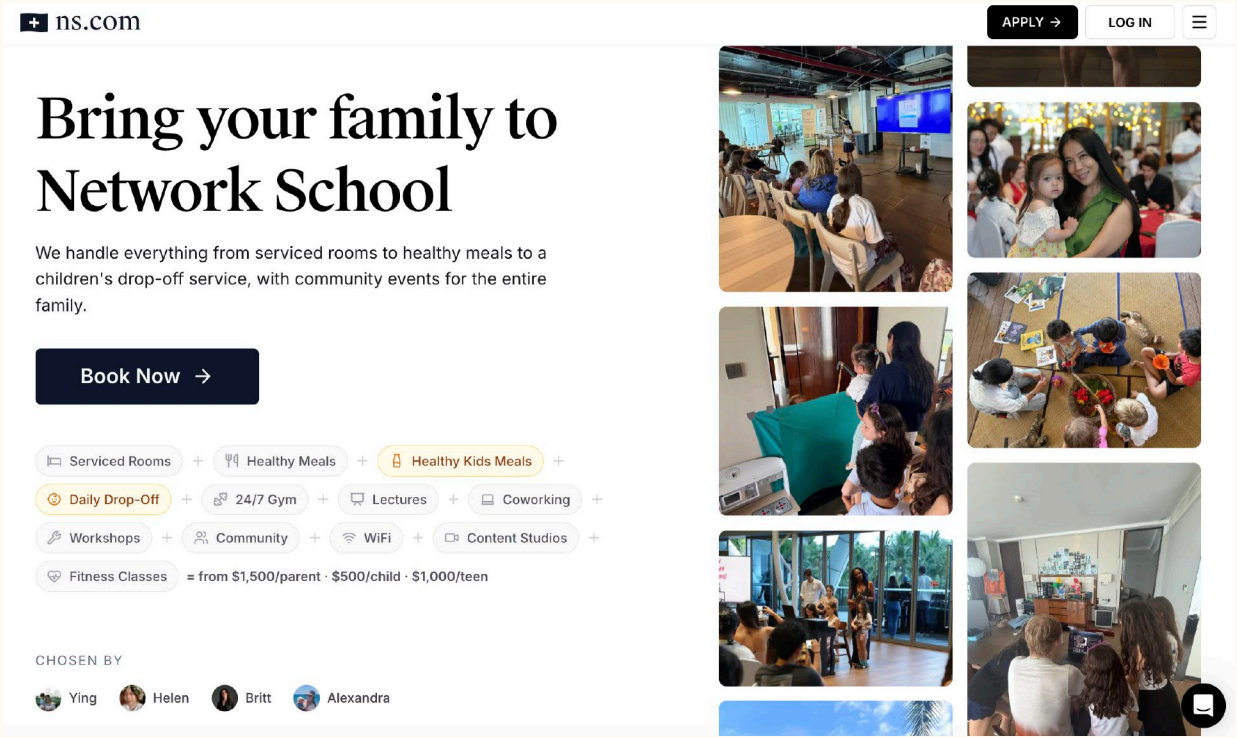
The Friction

4. Lack of development

The main differentiator from digital nomad co-living at the moment is hope that it will be more than it is. The vision is not yet reality and they are struggling to retain long term residents.



Families


ns.com
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Bring your family to Network School
We handle everything from serviced rooms to healthy meals to a children's drop-off service, with community events for the entire family.
Book Now →
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Healthy Meals
Healthy Kids Meals
Daily Drop-Off
24/7 Gym
Lectures
Coworking
Workshops
Community
WiFi
Content Studios
Fitness Classes
= from $1,500/parent · $500/child · $1,000/teen
CHOSEN BY
Ying
Helen
Britt
Alexandra

The critical mass problem

LACK OF INFRASTRUCTURE

Don't yet have a focus on infrastructure or culture to compete with other global cities or attract families long term

MANY FOCUSED ON DIGITAL NOMADS

A demographic that is open to moving but very mobile and often leave after a few months

INVOLVEMENT OF LOCAL POPULATION

NS actively cuts itself off. Other projects are starting to involve local population but provision of jobs will be the turning point.

LITTLE FOCUS ON COMMUNITY BUILDING

Many founders of permanent projects aren't involving potential residents in their development or focused on building community



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What's this all about?

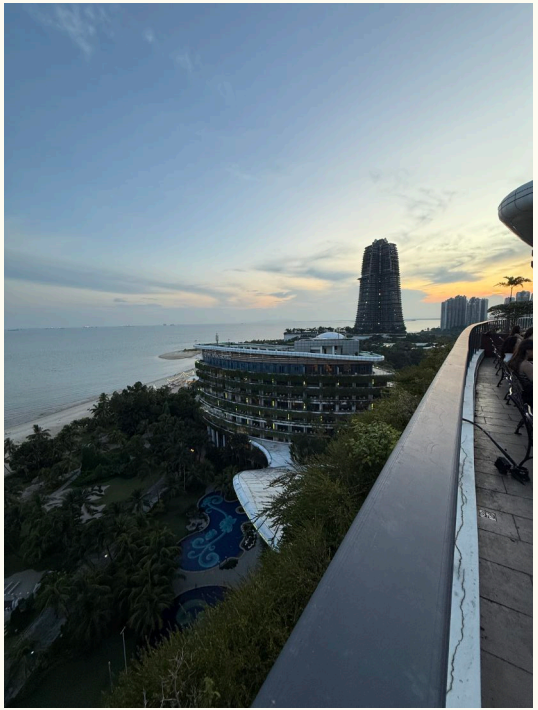
If it is about reimagining land...

- Only makes sense if it has real territory

- Must solve some of the issues prevalent in existing systems housing, civic engagement, sovereignty

- Must be permanent - not a retreat or co-living stay



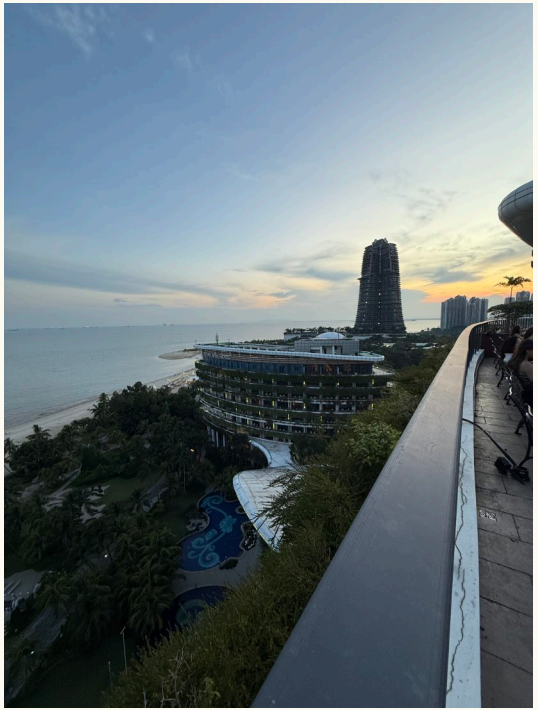


What's this all about?

If it is about reimagining land...

- Needs to create economic opportunities and incentives to stay and grow the permanent population





What’s this all about?

If it's about belonging...

- The real innovation is in the social layer, not the land

- The territory is a symbol of permanence - the community is the product



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